



Linux Certifications Hot or Not?

Industry stalwarts share their views on the importance of Linux certifications.

While Linux is gaining popularity at a fast pace, related certifications are also getting a lot of attention. There are many Linux certification courses of different levels today, but people are confused about how they can benefit from them. LFY spoke to various people from the industry and educational institutes, and to students, about how much weight these certifications carry in today's corporate world.

Why are certifications gaining popularity?

A survey conducted by the Linux Foundation earlier last year indicates that the adoption of Linux is overtaking Windows at the enterprise level at quite a rapid pace. About 80 per cent of the respondents mentioned that they plan to add more Linux-based servers to their business' infrastructure within the next five years, while only 21 per cent plan to add additional Microsoft-based servers. "Now, with the rate of adoption of open source-based technologies on the rise, techies find that open source expertise, which was earlier only a passion for them, can now also provide a strong career option in enterprises, as well as in government entities that have large deployments of open source-based technologies," states Narayana Menon K, head of Strategy and Marketing, Novell India Pvt Ltd. "The key players of the Linux and open source market, like SUSE, dominate the enterprise space in terms of deployment of Linux flavours. Hence, certifications on these would make more sense from an employability perspective. Certification courses like the Novell Certified Linux Professional (NCLP), Novell Certified Linux Administrator (NCLA) and Novell Certified Linux Engineer (NCLE) courses offer candidates the core skills required to handle the minute of a Linux environment. These

programs differentiate themselves from others available in the market through in-depth modules like shell scripting, which enables the certified to not just be restricted to peripheral admin roles, but also opens up opportunities to work on R&D, product enhancements, etc," Menon shares. Akshay Bhat, assistant professor at Manipal Institute of Technology, MCA department, adds that such foundation courses would be appropriate for students to build a sound and progressive career. "There is a wide array of courses available today like an introduction to Linux operating systems such as Red Hat and Fedora, Linux systems administration, Web application development on Linux platforms (Java, AJAX and Android), OS virtualisation, designing applications for cloud deployment, and computing and kernel programming. Students can evolve into experts in a particular domain based on their experience and knowledge," Bhat states.

Organisations that receive many profiles also find it easier to sift through candidates' profiles when they are certified. Ramandeep Singh, CEO, Calsoft Labs, reveals, "For any job post, we find it easier to filter candidates based on their qualifications and certifications. Certificate holders are naturally expected to know certain things, having gone through a structured course. Certifications also tell us that the candidate is more likely to be keen to pursue a career in open source technologies. It is important when we are trying to build a core team to focus in this area." Certifications also enhance the skills of employees working in a particular area. Calsoft Labs encourages its employees to undertake certification exams to test their knowledge, and to take additional courses to upgrade their skills in areas where a skill gap is perceived.

Do certifications help?

The big question is, "Will a Linux certification help get you a job?" People from the open source industry feel that certifications can take freshers a long way. "Students who are fresh out of college often do not have the required skill set to work on Linux," shares Sajith A, CEO at ZFramez Technologies, a start-up working in